

Cover to Cover
1 Kings
Teaching Notes

1 Kings —the book is much more than a record of kings—it is the story of **how a nation moved from covenant faithfulness to compromise, and from unity to division.**

1 & 2 Kings is written as **theological history**, meaning every event is recorded to answer one question:

Will God's people remain loyal to the covenant, or will they trade His presence for power, prosperity, and political security?

The Story of 1 Kings

The book begins with an elderly David passing the torch to Solomon.

It reaches breathtaking heights:

- A kingdom united.
- The Temple built.
- God's glory filling His house.
- The wisest king on earth.
- Israel becoming a light to the nations.

Yet slowly, almost imperceptibly, compromise enters.

One divided heart leads to:

- Divided worship.
- Divided loyalties.
- Divided leadership.
- Divided kingdoms.

By the end of the book:

- The kingdom is fractured.
- Idolatry is widespread.
- Wicked kings dominate Israel.
- Judah struggles to remain faithful.
- Prophets become God's primary voice to the nation.

Yet one truth shines through every chapter:

THE BOOK

This is the second in the series of three double books. They were originally one book and we will study them as such because they tell a continuing story.

"This is the second in the series of three double books,"

it means:

- **Samuel** is the first double book.
- **Kings** is the second double book.
- **Chronicles** is the third double book.

1 Kings records, the division of the United Kingdom of Saul, David and Solomon into two kingdoms.... and it will be known after that as Israel and Judah.

2 Kings records, the collapse or should we say, the captivity of both, Judah, and Israel.

The name, Israel, comprising 10 of the tribes, becomes the northern Kingdom with Samaria as the capital.

The kingdom of Judah, comprising two tribes, Judah and Benjamin, becomes the southern kingdom with Jerusalem as the capital.

Now, fix this in your mind because it is necessary if you are to understand the remainder of the Old Testament books.

Northern Kingdom – Israel – 10 tribes – Samaria
Southern kingdom – Judah – two tribes – Jerusalem

THE AUTHOR

The author of Kings is unknown. Tradition says Jeremiah wrote them, but this is not conclusive.

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE OF 1 KINGS

The main message is division because of disobedience.

This is clearly seen in 1 king 11:11 which marks the tragic turning point and becomes the key to the whole story.

(READ THIS VERSE AND NOTICE THE LAST PART OF THAT VERSE.)

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK OF 1 KINGS

The great 40 year reign of King Solomon – chapters 1-11.
(In 1/2 of the book, we have one United Kingdom.)

The first 80 years of the two kingdoms – chapter 12-22.

(In 1/2 of the book we follow the two kingdoms and their leaders)

THE FORTY YEAR REIGN OF SOLOMON — CHAPTER 1-11

1. Solomon was the last of the kings to reign over a United Hebrew Kingdom. He was just a child according to chapter 3:7 when he became king.

2. Notice Solomon's prayer for wisdom and understanding.
(Read chapter 3:5-13 and notice God's promise in verse 5.)

Compare this with Matthew 7:7

Solomon's request in verse 9... Compare with James 1: 5

The answer of the Lord in verses 12-13

This whole prayer is also recorded in 2 Chronicles 1: 7-13

3. The wisdom of Solomon... 4:29-34. Let's read this and notice verse 32.

4. Solomon begins to build the first temple in chapter 6 and the prayer of dedication is given in chapter 8.

Now let's look at 2 Chronicles 7:1-3
Who filled the temple?

5. The Lord's warning and promise to Solomon 9: 3-9.

Notice the conditions, the Lord gave in verse 6.

6. Solomon's transgression against God is revealed in chapter 11.

Some 4 1/2 centuries before, God had written the qualifications for all future kings of Israel.

Read Deut 17:14-17.

Solomon had disobeyed God in all these areas:
He had much silver and gold - 1 Kings 10:14-27
He had thousands of horses - 4:26
He had hundreds of wives and concubines - 11:3

7. The result of Solomon's transgression:
The Lord says the kingdom will be divided after the death of Solomon - 11:9-13 and 31.

8. Solomon's death and the rest of his works are recorded in 11:41-43. Look up Galatians 6:7.

THE FIRST EIGHTY YEARS OF THE TWO KINGDOMS CHAPTERS 12-22

Immediately after the death of Solomon, the division of the kingdom takes place in 10 tribes are led by Jeroboam ... Two by Rehoboam, which is the son of Solomon. Chapter 12:16-22.

LIST OF ALL THE KINGS OF EACH SIDE HERE.

The sins of Israel (the north) 12:25-33.

Jeroboam built false centers of worship at Dan and Bethel to keep the people from going to Jerusalem to worship — he made “Priests of the lowest people, not of the sons of Levi.”

And again, we see the judgement of God — 14:14-16

There are two lines of Kings during this 80 year period of 1 Kings, Judah had four kings.

Israel had eight..

(Look at your list of kings)

The Kings of 1 Kings

A Teacher's Guide to the Story Behind Each King

Based on the biblical text with insights reflected in Enduring Word and Tom Bradford's studies.

UNITED KINGDOM

David

Good King | **Reigned:** 40 years | **Son of:** Jesse

The Story Behind the King

David was Israel's greatest king and the man with whom God established an everlasting covenant. By the opening of 1 Kings, David is elderly and bedridden. Although he had defeated Israel's enemies and united the nation under one kingdom, he left behind unresolved family conflicts because of earlier failures in disciplining his sons.

How He Came to Reign

God rejected Saul and chose David while he was still a shepherd boy. After years of waiting, persecution, and civil war, David became king over all twelve tribes.

What Defined His Reign

- United the twelve tribes.
- Established Jerusalem as Israel's capital.
- Brought the Ark of the Covenant to Jerusalem.
- Received the Davidic Covenant that one of his descendants would reign forever (fulfilled in Jesus).

How He Died

David died peacefully after charging Solomon to remain faithful to God's covenant and to administer justice where it had previously been delayed.

Lasting Legacy

David established the royal line through which the Messiah would eventually come. Every king of Judah would later be compared to David.

Solomon

Good King who later compromised | **Reigned:** 40 years | **Son of:** David

The Story Behind the King

Solomon inherited the strongest kingdom Israel would ever possess. He began with remarkable humility by asking God for wisdom. His reign became Israel's "Golden Age," yet his later years became a warning that success can become dangerous when devotion fades.

How He Came to Reign

Although Adonijah attempted to seize the throne, David publicly declared Solomon to be God's chosen successor, and Zadok anointed him king.

What Made Him a Good King

- Asked God for wisdom instead of wealth.
- Built the Temple in Jerusalem.
- Expanded Israel's borders and prosperity.
- Became famous throughout the ancient world.

What Led to His Downfall

His many political marriages introduced pagan worship into Israel. Instead of influencing the nations for God, the nations influenced him. He built shrines for foreign gods, tolerated idolatry, and burdened the people with heavy taxation and forced labor.

Factions That Developed

Near the end of his reign, God raised up adversaries—including Hadad, Rezon, and Jeroboam—to oppose Solomon because of his unfaithfulness.

How He Died

Solomon died a natural death, and his son Rehoboam inherited the throne.

Lasting Legacy

He proved that wisdom alone cannot protect someone whose heart slowly drifts away from God.

KINGDOM OF JUDAH (SOUTHERN KINGDOM)

Rehoboam

Evil King | **Reigned:** 17 years | **Son of:** Solomon

The Story Behind the King

Rehoboam inherited the united kingdom but lost most of it within days. When the people asked him to lighten the heavy burdens Solomon had placed on them, he rejected the wisdom of the older counselors and followed the advice of his young friends.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne as Solomon's son.

What Made Him an Evil King

Although Judah still worshiped the Lord, Rehoboam allowed idolatry, pagan shrines, and immoral worship practices to flourish throughout the land.

Factions That Developed

His harsh leadership caused ten tribes to revolt under Jeroboam, permanently dividing Israel into two kingdoms.

How He Died

He died naturally and was buried with David's descendants in Jerusalem.

Lasting Legacy

One arrogant decision split the nation forever.

Abijam (Abijah)

Evil King | **Reigned:** 3 years | **Son of:** Rehoboam

The Story Behind the King

Abijam continued many of his father's sinful practices. Although he was personally unfaithful, God preserved his dynasty because of His covenant with David rather than Abijam's righteousness.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne from his father.

What Made Him an Evil King

He allowed idolatry to continue and failed to lead Judah wholeheartedly toward God.

Factions That Developed

Judah remained in continual conflict with Jeroboam's northern kingdom.

How He Died

He died naturally after only three years.

Lasting Legacy

God's covenant faithfulness was greater than Abijam's personal faithfulness.

Asa

Good King | **Reigned:** 41 years | **Son of:** Abijam

The Story Behind the King

Asa became one of Judah's greatest reformers. He courageously removed idols, destroyed pagan altars, and even removed his own grandmother from her royal position because she promoted idol worship.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne after his father's death.

What Made Him a Good King

He sought the Lord wholeheartedly during most of his reign and restored covenant worship.

Weaknesses

Later in life, he relied on political alliances instead of trusting God and failed to seek the Lord during a serious illness.

How He Died

He died of a disease in his feet after reigning forty-one years.

Lasting Legacy

He demonstrated that even faithful leaders must finish well.

Jehoshaphat

Good King | **Reigned:** 25 years | **Son of:** Asa

The Story Behind the King

Jehoshaphat sincerely loved God and strengthened Judah spiritually by sending teachers throughout the nation with the Book of the Law. He desired that people know God's Word rather than merely observe religious rituals.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne from his father Asa.

What Made Him a Good King

- Strengthened biblical teaching.
- Promoted justice.
- Sought God's counsel before major decisions.

His Greatest Weakness

He repeatedly formed political alliances with wicked King Ahab. These compromises nearly cost him his life and later introduced Baal worship into David's royal family through marriage.

How He Died

He died peacefully after a long reign.

Lasting Legacy

A godly heart still requires godly discernment.

KINGDOM OF ISRAEL (NORTHERN KINGDOM)

Jeroboam I

Evil King | **Reigned:** 22 years | **Son of:** Nebat

The Story Behind the King

Jeroboam was originally one of Solomon's most capable officials. God promised him ten tribes through the prophet Ahijah because of Solomon's idolatry. Instead of trusting God's promise, Jeroboam trusted political strategy.

How He Came to Reign

God appointed him to rule the ten northern tribes after the kingdom divided.

What Made Him an Evil King

Fearing that his people would return to Jerusalem to worship, he established counterfeit worship centers at Bethel and Dan with golden calves, unauthorized priests, and substitute feast days.

Factions That Developed

He permanently separated the northern kingdom from Jerusalem's Temple worship.

How He Died

He died naturally, but God later wiped out his entire family because of his rebellion.

Lasting Legacy

Nearly every future northern king is judged by whether he continued "the sins of Jeroboam."

Nadab

Evil King | **Reigned:** 2 years | **Son of:** Jeroboam I

The Story Behind the King

Nadab simply continued his father's idolatrous policies.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne after Jeroboam's death.

What Made Him an Evil King

He refused to abandon the golden calf worship.

How He Died

He was assassinated by Baasha during a military campaign.

Lasting Legacy

His death ended Jeroboam's dynasty.

Baasha

Evil King | **Reigned:** 24 years | **Son of:** Ahijah (of Issachar)

The Story Behind the King

Baasha assassinated Nadab and became king. God used him to fulfill the prophecy against Jeroboam's family, but once on the throne he committed the same sins.

What Made Him an Evil King

He preserved Jeroboam's false religion and ignored God's warnings.

Factions That Developed

His violent rise established a new dynasty through assassination rather than inheritance.

How He Died

He died naturally, but God announced that his entire family would also be destroyed.

Lasting Legacy

God may use someone to accomplish His purposes, yet still hold that person accountable.

Elah

Evil King | **Reigned:** 2 years | **Son of:** Baasha

The Story Behind the King

Elah inherited a kingdom but lacked strong leadership.

What Made Him an Evil King

He continued the sins of Jeroboam.

How He Died

While drunk at one of his officials' homes, he was assassinated by Zimri.

Lasting Legacy

His careless leadership left the kingdom vulnerable.

Zimri

Evil King | **Reigned:** 7 days | **Son of:** Not recorded

The Story Behind the King

Zimri seized power by murdering Elah and eliminating Baasha's family.

How He Came to Reign

Military coup.

What Made Him an Evil King

He continued Israel's idolatry despite witnessing God's judgment on previous dynasties.

Factions That Developed

The army rejected him almost immediately and proclaimed Omri king instead.

How He Died

When Omri surrounded the capital, Zimri burned the royal palace around himself and died.

Lasting Legacy

His seven-day reign became one of Scripture's greatest examples of political instability.

Tibni

No Spiritual Evaluation Recorded | **Rival Claimant (approximately 4 years)** | **Son of:** Ginath

The Story Behind the King

After Zimri's death, Israel split into two political factions. Half supported Omri, while the other half supported Tibni.

How He Came to Power

He became the leader of one faction during the civil conflict.

Factions That Developed

Israel experienced a civil war until Omri eventually prevailed.

How He Died

Scripture simply records that Tibni died before Omri became sole ruler.

Lasting Legacy

His brief appearance reveals how divided and unstable the northern kingdom had become.

Omri

Evil King | **Reigned:** 12 years | **Son of:** Not recorded

The Story Behind the King

Omri emerged victorious after Israel's civil war. Although secular history remembers him as one of Israel's strongest rulers, Scripture remembers him for leading Israel deeper into idolatry.

How He Came to Reign

Chosen by the army and victorious over Tibni.

What Made Him an Evil King

He surpassed all previous kings in wickedness.

Major Achievement

He purchased the hill of Samaria and established it as Israel's permanent capital.

How He Died

He died naturally and passed the throne to Ahab.

Lasting Legacy

Political greatness without spiritual faithfulness is failure in God's eyes.

Ahab

Evil King | **Reigned:** 22 years | **Son of:** Omri

The Story Behind the King

Ahab became Israel's most infamous king. His marriage to Jezebel brought Baal worship to the center of Israel's national life. During his reign, Elijah confronted him repeatedly, calling the nation back to the Lord.

How He Came to Reign

Inherited the throne from Omri.

What Made Him an Evil King

- Married Jezebel.
- Built a temple for Baal.
- Promoted idol worship nationwide.

- Persecuted God's prophets.
- Stole Naboth's vineyard through murder and injustice.

Major Events

- Drought announced by Elijah.
- Mount Carmel showdown.
- Miraculous victories over Syria.
- Naboth's vineyard.
- Micaiah's prophecy.

How He Died

Ignoring Micaiah's warning, Ahab disguised himself in battle. A random arrow struck him between the joints of his armor. He bled to death in his chariot, and dogs later licked up his blood exactly as Elijah had prophesied.

Lasting Legacy

He became the standard by which Israel's most wicked rulers were measured.

FINAL KING INTRODUCED IN 1 KINGS

Ahaziah

Evil King | **Reigned:** 2 years | **Son of:** Ahab

The Story Behind the King

Ahaziah appears only briefly at the close of 1 Kings, but his reign continues the tragic legacy of his parents.

How He Came to Reign

He inherited the throne after Ahab's death.

What Made Him an Evil King

He followed the idolatrous example of Ahab and Jezebel, serving Baal and continuing the sins of Jeroboam.

How He Died

His death is recorded in 2 Kings 1. After falling through the lattice of his upper room, he sought guidance from Baal-zebub instead of the Lord. Elijah announced God's judgment, and Ahaziah died from his injuries without an heir.

Lasting Legacy

His reign demonstrates that children often inherit not only a throne but also the spiritual consequences of the choices made by their parents.

ENTER THE PROPHET ELIJAH—CHAPTERS 17-22

1 Kings 17

Elijah Suddenly Appears

What Was Happening

Without warning, one of the greatest prophets in Scripture steps onto the stage.

No genealogy.

No background.

No introduction.

Simply:

"Now Elijah..."

The last six chapters of 1 Kings gives the ministry of Elijah, the prophet, in the northern Kingdom of Israel... The 10 tribes.

The New Testament speaks of him more than any other prophet.

It was Elijah, who appeared with Moses at Jesus transfiguration in Matthew 17:1-5.

It is at this point in the divided kingdoms that the work of God's prophets is emphasized.

Elijah just suddenly appears as a crisis – prophet and disappears as suddenly in a chariot of fire... We will see this in 2 Kings 2:11.

Between his appearing and his disappearing, there is a whole succession of miracles.

He was a prophet of deeds... He wrote nothing.

He pronounced for God:
Three years of drought in chapter 17:1

Elijah boldly announces to Ahab that there will be neither dew nor rain except by God's word. This directly challenges Baal, who was believed to control storms and fertility. God is demonstrating that He—not Baal—rules creation.

He was a thorn in the side of king Ahab in chapter 18:17
Miracles are recorded by Elijah.

Elijah teaches us that God always has a man to match the hour.

After fleeing from a threat on his life in chapter 19:2, he is told to go back and find an annoyed 2 Kings and find Elisha and begin training him to succeed him...
Chapter 19:15–16.

Elijah pronounced doom on King Ahab in chapter 21:19 and it came to pass in chapter 22:38

Elijah proves what God can do through a man when the truth of God is being hurt by a person or a nation.

God remains faithful even when His people are not.

Though kings rise and fall, kingdoms divide, and generations wander, God continues preserving the line of David because He has already promised that one day a greater King will come.

That King is **Jesus Christ**.

Unlike Solomon, His heart would never be divided.

Unlike Ahab, He would never abuse His authority.

Unlike every earthly king in 1 Kings, Jesus would reign in perfect righteousness forever.

Major Themes of 1 Kings

God's Presence is Greater than Any Building

The Temple was never the destination—it pointed to God's desire to dwell with His people.

Wisdom Without Obedience Leads to Failure

Solomon possessed extraordinary wisdom, but knowledge alone could not protect a divided heart.

Leadership Always Influences a Nation

The spiritual condition of the people consistently reflected the spiritual condition of their leaders.

Idolatry Always Begins in the Heart

Before idols appeared on hillsides, compromise had already taken root within hearts.

God Always Preserves a Faithful Remnant

Whether through Obadiah, Elijah, Micaiah, or the seven thousand who had not bowed to Baal, God always had people who remained faithful.

God's Word Never Fails

Every prophecy spoken throughout 1 Kings came to pass exactly as God declared, reminding us that His promises—and His warnings—can always be trusted.

Unlike the books of **1 & 2 Samuel**, where many psalms have historical titles ("when David fled from Saul," etc.), **very few psalms have inspired headings that connect them directly to the events of 1 Kings.**

Psalms Connected to the Reign of Solomon (1 Kings 1–11)

Psalms 72

Connected to: 1 Kings 1–10

Author: Solomon (or "for Solomon")

Historical Setting

- Solomon's coronation
- His reign of peace
- Expansion of Israel
- The Queen of Sheba
- Israel's prosperity

Connection

This psalm paints the ideal picture of the king God desired Solomon to become.

It speaks of:

- Justice
- Righteous government
- Peace
- Worldwide dominion
- Kings bringing gifts
- Blessing to all nations

Many phrases clearly exceed Solomon's reign and ultimately point to Jesus, the greater Son of David.

Related chapters

- 1 Kings 1
- 1 Kings 2
- 1 Kings 3
- 1 Kings 4
- 1 Kings 5
- 1 Kings 8
- 1 Kings 10

Psalm 127

Connected to: 1 Kings 5–8

Author: Solomon

Historical Setting

Construction of the Temple and royal building projects.

"Unless the LORD builds the house..."

The irony becomes powerful because Solomon literally built God's house while later failing to guard his own spiritual house.

Themes:

- Dependence upon God
- Building God's way
- Family
- Legacy

Psalm 132

Connected to: 1 Kings 8

Although written about David's desire to establish God's dwelling place, Psalm 132 reaches its fulfillment when Solomon dedicates the Temple.

Notice these parallels:

Psalm 132	1 Kings 8
David desired a house for God	Solomon completed it
Ark comes to Zion	Ark placed in Temple
God chooses Zion	Glory fills Temple
Priests clothed in righteousness	Priests minister before God

Psalms Reflecting Solomon's Spiritual Decline

Psalm 127 (ironically)

Many teachers point out that the warning of Psalm 127 becomes a commentary on Solomon's later life.

By 1 Kings 11 Solomon:

- trusted political alliances
- multiplied wives
- accumulated wealth
- depended on human strength

rather than simply resting in God's provision.

Psalms Connected to the Temple Dedication

Psalm 84

Although probably written later by the Sons of Korah, it beautifully reflects the worship life established through Solomon's Temple.

Connected to:

1 Kings 8

Themes:

- God's courts
- Worship
- Pilgrimage
- Joy in God's house

Psalm 122

A Song of Ascents by David.

David anticipated Jerusalem becoming the center of worship.

1 Kings 8 fulfills much of that anticipation as the Temple becomes Israel's central place of worship.

Psalm 24

Many scholars believe this psalm was originally associated with bringing the Ark into Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6), but its language naturally fits the Ark's entrance into the completed Temple in 1 Kings 8.

Psalms Reflecting the Division of the Kingdom

Psalm 78

Connected to: 1 Kings 11–12

This historical psalm recounts Israel's repeated rebellion against God.

Its warnings explain why the kingdom divided after Solomon's disobedience.

Key themes:

- Forgetting God's works
- Idolatry
- Covenant failure
- God's judgment
- Leadership failure

Psalm 81

Connected to:

Jeroboam's establishment of calf worship (1 Kings 12).

The psalm repeatedly laments:

"My people would not listen..."

making it an appropriate theological commentary on Israel's rejection of God's ways.

Psalms Connected to Ahab and Elijah's Conflict

Psalm 37

The conflict between Elijah and Ahab illustrates the truth of this wisdom psalm:

"Do not fret because of evildoers..."

Elijah watches wicked rulers prosper—for a season—but God ultimately vindicates His servant.

Psalm 50

The confrontation on Mount Carmel centers on true worship versus empty religion.

Psalm 50 likewise rebukes superficial worship and calls God's people to genuine covenant faithfulness, fitting the themes of 1 Kings 18.

One of the striking features of **1 Kings** is that it contains relatively few psalms that can be confidently dated to its events. Instead, the book emphasizes the rise and fall of Israel's kings, while the Psalms provide the theological lens through which those events are understood—

celebrating God's covenant with David, calling kings to righteous rule, warning against idolatry, and ultimately directing readers to the perfect King, Jesus Christ, who succeeds where Solomon, Ahab, and every earthly king failed.